

STEEL MAGNOLIA

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1 INT. NURSING HOME ACTIVITIES ROOM - DAY

Fluorescent lights hum over folding tables where ELDERLY RESIDENTS work on a jigsaw puzzle of kittens. Motivational posters peel from yellowed walls.

EDNA MAE THORNTON, 84, sits apart from the group in her wheelchair. Silver hair pinned in victory rolls. Red lipstick applied with military precision. She wears a vintage brooch shaped like a bomber plane on her cardigan. She's reading "The Art of War" by Sun Tzu.

A ACTIVITIES COORDINATOR, 20s, approaches with aggressive cheerfulness.

ACTIVITIES COORDINATOR

Mrs. Thornton! Why don't you come join the puzzle group? We're almost done with the kitties!

EDNA MAE

((without looking up))

I riveted B-17 bombers during the war, sweetheart. I'm not about to spend my remaining days assembling cartoon cats.

ACTIVITIES COORDINATOR

But socialization is so important--

EDNA MAE

So is dignity. Yet here we are.

Edna Mae turns a page. The Coordinator retreats.

GERALD, 79, shuffles over. He's wearing a WWII Veteran cap, walks with a cane.

GERALD

You know, Edna Mae, you could try being pleasant. Just once. See how it feels.

EDNA MAE

I tried pleasant in 1987. Didn't care for it.

GERALD

((sitting beside her))

What's got your propeller spinning backwards today?

EDNA MAE

My granddaughter's coming. She wants to discuss my "living situation."

GERALD

Ah. The talk.

EDNA MAE

I didn't survive a factory explosion, three husbands, and the Reagan administration to be "discussed" like a problem that needs solving.

She closes the book. Her hands shake slightly -- early Parkinson's -- but her eyes are sharp as tacks.

EDNA MAE (CONT'D)

Hand me my bag, Gerald.

Gerald retrieves a large leather purse. Edna Mae pulls out a folder thick with papers.

GERALD

What's that?

EDNA MAE

Reconnaissance.

2 INT. NURSING HOME - EDNA MAE'S ROOM - LATER

A small room transformed into a museum of a life fully lived. Framed photos cover every surface -- Edna Mae shaking hands with Eleanor Roosevelt, working a factory line, dancing with a soldier.

A "Rosie the Riveter" poster hangs prominently. Below it: her actual riveting certification, framed.

JENNIFER THORNTON, 35, professional attire, sits on the bed clutching a brochure for "Sunrise Senior Living." She has Edna Mae's same stubborn jawline.

Edna Mae wheels herself to face her granddaughter directly.

JENNIFER

Grandma, I'm just saying the memory care unit has better facilities--

EDNA MAE

My memory is the only thing working perfectly, Jennifer Lynn. Ask me what you wore to your piano recital in 1996.

JENNIFER

That's not--

EDNA MAE

Purple velvet dress. You hated it. You played Für Elise and missed the same note three times.

JENNIFER

((sighing))

Your hands, Grandma. The shaking is getting worse.

EDNA MAE

((lifting her trembling hands))

These hands built planes that won
a war. They changed your father's
diapers. They signed divorce
papers twice -- should've been
three times, but Harold died
first.

((beat))

They've earned the right to
shake.

Jennifer sets down the brochure. Her corporate armor
cracks slightly.

JENNIFER

I'm scared, okay? I got a call
last week that you fell in the
bathroom.

EDNA MAE

I didn't fall. I was testing
gravity. It still works.

JENNIFER

Grandma.

EDNA MAE

Jennifer.

A standoff. Two generations of Thornton stubbornness.
Edna Mae wheels closer, takes Jennifer's hand in her
trembling one.

EDNA MAE (CONT'D)

When your grandfather shipped out
in '43, I was nineteen.
Terrified. Everyone told me to go
home, wait like a good girl.

((beat))

Instead, I lied about my age,
learned to rivet, and built the
plane he flew home in.

JENNIFER

I know, Grandma. I've heard the
story.

EDNA MAE

Then you've heard the wrong
version.

((beat))

I wasn't brave. I was terrified
every single day. But fear and
courage, honey -- they're not
opposites. They're dance
partners.

Jennifer looks at the photos. Really looks at them.

EDNA MAE (CONT'D)

I'm not asking to live forever.
I'm asking to live (mine). What's
left of it.

Edna Mae pulls out her folder, hands it to Jennifer.

EDNA MAE (CONT'D)

I've updated my will. My DNR is
signed. My affairs are in order.
I even wrote my own obituary --
it's better than anything you
people would come up with.

Jennifer laughs despite herself.

JENNIFER

You're impossible.

EDNA MAE

I'm a Thornton. Same as you.

3 INT. NURSING HOME HALLWAY - LATER

Jennifer walks toward the exit, folder in hand. She passes the activities room.

Through the window, she sees Edna Mae wheeling toward the puzzle group. The old woman pulls up to the table.

The residents look up, surprised.

EDNA MAE

All right, which one of you put
the orange tabby in the wrong
corner? This is amateur hour.

She starts reorganizing pieces with trembling but determined hands.

Gerald catches Jennifer watching. He raises his coffee cup in salute.

Jennifer smiles, wipes her eyes, and walks out.

4 EXT. NURSING HOME - PARKING LOT - CONTINUOUS

Jennifer reaches her car, stops. She looks at the brochure in her hand.

She crumples it. Throws it in a nearby trash can.

From her pocket, she pulls out her phone. Dials.

JENNIFER

((into phone))

Hey, it's me. Cancel the tour at
Sunrise.

((beat))

Because she's fine where she is.

((beat))

Yeah. She's a Thornton.

She hangs up. Gets in her car.

FADE OUT.

THE END